



SHUT SANCTUARY Left, a Bhopal *rubaat* in Medina; above, file photo of M.A.K. Pataudi with his family

▶ MADHYA PRADESH

Inheriting a Legacy of Trouble

The Bhopal *rubaats*—inns for Haj pilgrims—trigger a bitter war of words as politicos target ex-royalty

continue. Quiet by temperament, Saba has largely kept her public life confined to this low-visibility trusteeship, via the good offices of Khan.

But Arif Masood, Congress MLA from Bhopal Central, alleges devil in the technical detail. Saba and Khan, he says, failed to complete the paperwork needed for the Mecca *rubaat* to be recognised as a place of stay by the Central Haj Committee. This *rubaat* has 210 seats for pilgrims from Bhopal, Raisen and Sehore—the area corresponding to the former state. When applications exceed this number, places are allotted by lottery. Those who secure a place have their stay covered and receive a refund of Rs 75,000 months later. Masood says delays in submitting papers mean no one can avail of this facility this year.

In Medina, where a *rubaat* can house around a thousand pilgrims, the building lies unused. There's a decade-long trail of litigation here. Documents submitted in the Madhya Pradesh Waqf Tribunal show a new building was purchased in Mecca's Azizia area for 18 million Saudi riyals (Rs 45 crore) in 2014 to function as a *rubaat*. But in Medina, says Citizens Welfare Forum president Mohammed Afaq, the changes on the ground were messier, and Saba, as the final custodian, ended up being removed by the court there. A recovery of 1.9 million Saudi riyals (Rs 4.84 crore) is still pending. And, in 2020, the court ordered that the *rubaat* be closed to pilgrims.

Khan, known for his charity work, denies the charges. In an aspect of hurt, he says all papers were submitted in time and he's trying his best to ensure the *rubaats* become functional. Saba, when contacted, said: "The Medina matter is sub judice and I am therefore unable to comment on it. The Mecca *rubaats* remain in the possession of my nazir." A curious twist came when BJP ex-MLA Dhruv Narayan Singh, who lost to Masood in the 2023 assembly election, came out to defend Khan. That may not assuage the Hajis. ■

Takeaways

- **Bhopal's Mecca, Medina *rubaats* in a row**
- **Congress MLA alleges mismanagement**
- **Saba Sultan, daughter of Pataudi, is custodian**